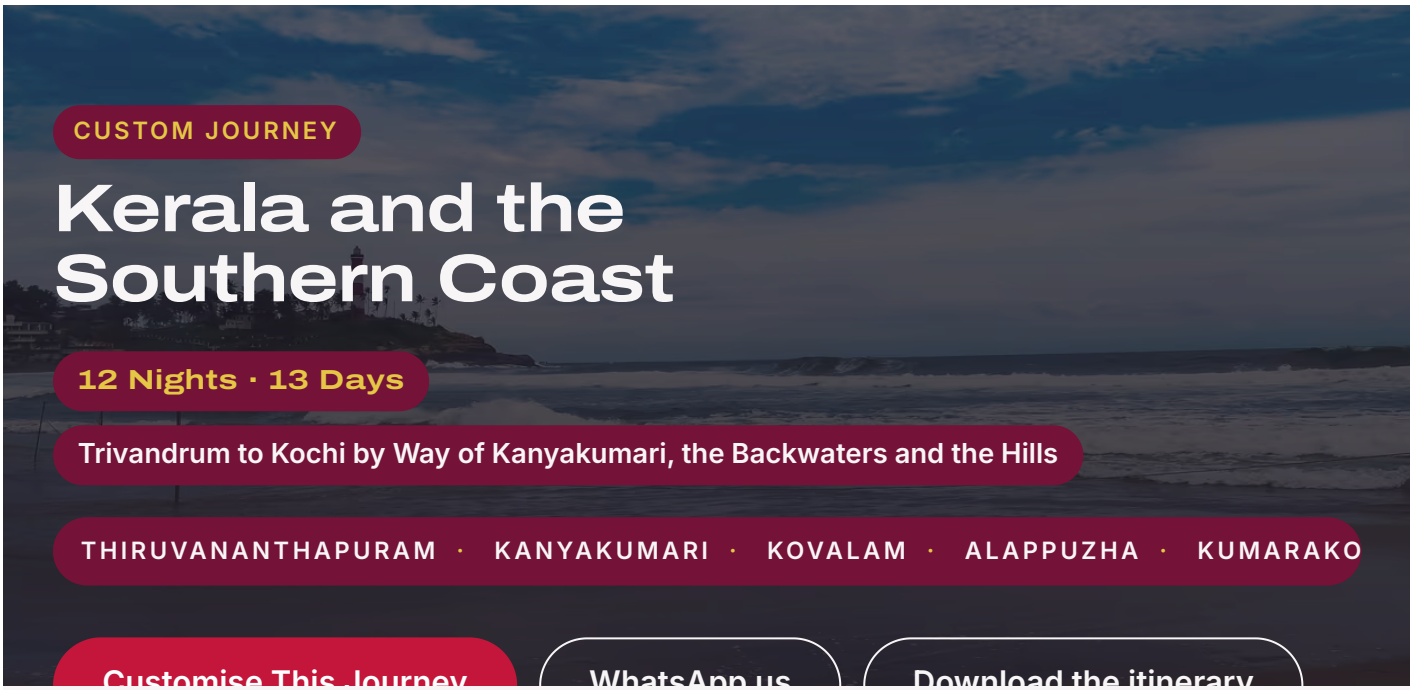
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DURATION
12 Nights · 13 Days

ROUTE
Thiruvananthapuram → Kochi

PACE
Relaxed

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Seniors, Families

This is Kerala from the south, which almost nobody does and which turns out to be the better order. It begins at Thiruvananthapuram, reaches Kanyakumari, where three seas meet at the very tip of the subcontinent, and only then turns north: the beaches at Kovalam, a houseboat from Alappuzha to Kumarakom, the tiger reserve at Periyar, the tea gardens at Munnar, and Kochi at the end, with its churches and its synagogue and its fishing nets.

Thirteen days is a long time in one state, and it is used slowly: two nights at almost every stop, three days with nothing planned, and a night on the water in the middle. It suits travellers who have been to India before and want one region done properly, and it suits anyone for whom the point of a holiday is not to hurry.

Journey Highlights

- **Stand** at Kanyakumari, where three seas meet at the tip of the subcontinent, and take the ferry to the Vivekananda Rock Memorial.
- **Rest** two full days on the beaches of Kovalam (Lighthouse, Hawa and Samudra), with Ayurveda in the resorts behind them.
- **Board** a houseboat at Alappuzha and cruise the canals to Kumarakom, past paddy fields and villages, for a night on the water.
- **Watch** the birds of the Kumarakom sanctuary on Vembanad Lake from a canoe in the evening.
- **Cruise** Periyar Lake inside the tiger reserve, where elephant, sambar and wild boar come down to the shore.
- **Climb** to Munnar's tea gardens below Anamudi, the highest peak in South India, with a day free among the waterfalls and estates.
- **End** in Kochi with the Portuguese churches, the synagogue, the Chinese fishing nets and, if you wish, an evening of Kathakali.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Thiruvananthapuram**	Arrival at leisure
Day 02	**Thiruvananthapuram**	Padmanabhaswamy Temple and the Napier Museum
Day 03	**Kanyakumari**	The tip of India; the Vivekananda Rock by ferry

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 04	**Kovalam**	To the coast; the beach and the Ayurveda resorts
Day 05	**Kovalam**	A day on the three beaches
Day 06	**Alappuzha**	Board a houseboat; cruise towards Kumarakom
Day 07	**Kumarakom**	Vembanad Lake and the bird sanctuary
Day 08	**Thekkady**	Periyar Lake boat cruise in the tiger reserve
Day 09	**Munnar**	Up into the tea gardens
Day 10	**Munnar**	Waterfalls, estates and Top Station
Day 11	**Kochi**	Down to the coast; an optional Kathakali evening
Day 12	**Kochi**	Churches, synagogue and Fort Kochi
Day 13	**Departure**	Transfer to Kochi airport

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Thiruvananthapuram: Arrival

Met on arrival at Thiruvananthapuram and taken to your hotel. The first day is at leisure. The capital of Kerala is a low, green, unhurried city, and it rewards an evening walk more than a programme.

Overnight in Thiruvananthapuram

Day 02 Thiruvananthapuram: The Temple and the Museum

The Sri Padmanabhaswamy Temple, the city's great Vishnu shrine, and then the Napier Museum: nineteenth-century Indo-Saracenic, with a collection of bronzes, old ornaments and a temple chariot, and the Sree Chithra Art Gallery holding paintings by Raja Ravi Varma and Nicholas Roerich. One of the oldest zoos in India sits in the same grounds. The museum is closed on Mondays, Wednesday afternoons and public holidays, and we plan around that. A free afternoon.

Overnight in Thiruvananthapuram

Day 03 Kanyakumari: The Tip of the Subcontinent

Drive · about 90 km each way

A full day's excursion south to Kanyakumari, where the Arabian Sea, the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean meet. The Bhagavathy and Suchindram temples are two of the Shakti Peethas; the ferry crosses to the Vivekananda Rock Memorial, and beside it stands the 133-foot statue of the Tamil poet-saint Thiruvalluvar. The Gandhi Memorial marks where his ashes were kept before immersion. Sunrise and sunset here are famous, and the timing of the day is arranged around one of them. Back to Thiruvananthapuram for the night.

Overnight in Thiruvananthapuram

Day 04 Kovalam: To the Coast

Drive · about 15 km

The short drive to Kovalam, and the change of pace that comes with it. A walk along the shore, the Halcyon Castle above the bay, and the Ayurvedic salons and resorts that have made this coast a destination in its own right. Settle in; the next day is entirely free.

Overnight in Kovalam

Day 05 Kovalam: Three Beaches

A day given to the beach. Kovalam has three: Lighthouse Beach under its rocky promontory, Hawa or Eve's Beach with the bluest water, and Samudra Beach, where you can try your hand with the local fishermen. The seaport at Vizhinjam, three kilometres away, has temples, churches and a mosque if you would like an hour away from the sand.

Overnight in Kovalam

Day 06 Alappuzha: Onto the Water

Boat · Board a houseboat at Alappuzha

North to Alappuzha, criss-crossed with canals: backwaters, beaches and lagoons that are any traveller's idea of Kerala. Kuttanad, beside it, is endless paddy and coconut palm, one of the few places on earth where rice is grown below sea level; in August the Nehru Trophy boat race fills Punnamada Lake. Board your houseboat here and cruise the backwaters towards Kumarakom, past village after village, with the night spent moored on the water.

Overnight aboard the houseboat

Day 07 Kumarakom: Vembanad Lake

Drive · about 55 km

To your hotel in Kumarakom, on the shore of the freshwater Vembanad Lake, for a free day. The farms around it grow banana, mango, jackfruit and pineapple in abundance; the Kumarakom Bird Sanctuary holds local and migratory species, and a short canoe trip in the evening is the best way to see them.

Overnight in Kumarakom

Day 08 Thekkady: Periyar by Boat

Drive · about 110 km

Up into the hills to Thekkady and the Periyar Tiger Reserve. The sanctuary's forest (banyan, teak, rosewood, tamarind, orchid) is as much the point as its animals, which include elephant, sambar, wild boar, wild dog and langur; tigers and leopards are present and rarely seen. A boat on Periyar Lake is the way to watch the shore, and the day ends early after the long climb.

Overnight in Thekkady

Day 09 Munnar: Into the Tea Gardens

Drive · about 90 km

Through the hills to Munnar and its tea plantations, below Anamudi, the highest peak in South India. The rest of the day is at leisure; the estates are best walked in the late afternoon light.

Overnight in Munnar

Day 10 Munnar: A Free Day in the Hills

A whole day free in Munnar. Attukad Waterfalls and the Chithirapuram estates are close by; the Floriculture Centre holds a range of flower and herbal species; Top Station gives a spectacular view across the Western Ghats. Munnar is also ringed by waterfalls and wildlife sanctuaries, and your driver can take you to whichever you choose.

Overnight in Munnar

Day 11 Kochi: Down to the Coast

Drive · about 125 km

Down from the hills to Kochi, and an afternoon to begin on a city that carries the marks of everyone who has visited it (Arab, Chinese, Portuguese, Dutch, British). In the evening, optionally, a Kathakali performance: the classical dance-drama of Kerala, with its painted faces and its hours of preparation, which is worth arriving early for.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Kochi

Day 12 Kochi: Churches, the Synagogue and the Fort

The morning in Fort Kochi and Mattancherry (the Portuguese churches, the mosques and temples, and the Paradesi synagogue of 1568 in Jew Town) and a free afternoon. The Hill Palace, the Chinese fishing nets, Cherai Beach and the marina are all within reach if you would like to fill it.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Kochi

Day 13 Kochi: Departure

Check out at noon and transfer to Kochi airport for your return flight.

Explore Kochi →

Departure

Practical notes

Getting there

Best time to visit

Fly into Thiruvananthapuram (TRV) and out of Kochi (COK). Both are international airports; the open-jaw routing is what lets the journey run south to north without doubling back.

Ideal duration

Thirteen days, because the journey reaches the tip of the subcontinent and still gives the coast, the backwaters and the hills two nights each.

October to March. The Kanyakumari sunrise, the backwaters and the hills are all at their best in the cool, dry months; the monsoon from June is green and heavy.

Pace

Relaxed. Short drives between neighbouring stops, three free days, and a houseboat night in the middle to slow everything down.